

The U.S. Education System Fails Fulfillment in the Workplace for the Disadvantaged

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Introduction

Since the secularization of education in the United States in 1963, academia was meant to teach the nation's youth practical knowledge and critical thinking skills, so that they can become contributing members of society (Lupu et al).¹ But, where does it actually leave our students? Are they succeeding in their courses, pursuing lifelong careers that engage them in critical analysis? More importantly, are they enjoying their work? Unfortunately, the answer to that last part is, more often than not, "no." The American education system does not effectively encourage students, especially those belonging to marginalized groups, to pursue careers that bring them personal fulfillment due to the presence of academic, financial, and social pressures within educational institutions. Personal fulfillment in the workplace is defined as having a job that one is not only able to live off of, but is passionate and enthusiastic about. With that said, despite efforts to aid students in that regard, *this* is why the American education system fails to guide its under-represented students in pursuing personal happiness in the workplace.

Well, what about the things schools do provide?

The resources schools currently provide for our students must first be accounted for. Some schools have guidance counselors whose jobs include aiding students in figuring out the most suitable career path. However, this system is not implemented adequately enough. The American School Counselor Association's website show that only about 50% of U.S. states require school counselors to be present in both K-8 and high schools (American School Counselor Association)². Additionally, according to data analyst Maya Riser-Kositsky, even in states that provide counseling, "[only] 8% of districts meet the recommended ratio of school

¹ All authors who contributed to this paper had credentials in either law, religion, or writing.

² The American School Counselor Association is a non-profit organization dedicated to supporting school counselors around the nation through centralizing and distributing resources

psychologists to students [, and just] 14% of districts meet the ideal student-to-counselor ratio” (Riser-Kositsky).³ Clearly, students are not given enough support in schools to assist them in planning for their future. Now then, how does the American education system push disadvantaged students away from pursuing careers that they find fulfillment in?

Academic Pressure

Students are often told by their family and school that their academic scores are what matters the most when it comes to succeeding in life. If you don’t get good marks, then you can’t graduate; if you can’t graduate, you can’t earn a degree; if you don’t have a degree, you can’t get a good job; that slippery slope goes on and on. This immense pressure causes students to be fearful of making errors, so they focus on getting the highest marks that they can rather than learning for the sake of knowledge. According to a study conducted by The Princeton Review, “[although] 90% of students say that getting good grades is important, less than 10% say that succeeding in school is important because of the value of learning [, and over] 40% of students responded that getting into college is the main driver of their desire to get good grades” (The Princeton Review).⁴ This affects Black and Hispanic students more than it does their White counterparts as the former groups often come from a disadvantaged background, such as being low-income. Thus, as described by research analyst Renee Stepler, their families emphasize achieving top scores because they believe that getting a higher education is the only way to move up the socioeconomic ladder (Stepler).⁵ From this, it’s evident that students from disadvantaged

³ Riser-Kositsky serves as a librarian and data specialist at EducationWeek, which is an independent news organization that reports on K-12 education.

⁴ The Princeton Review is a well known private company that provides educational resources for students looking to enter higher education.

⁵ Renee Stepler was a former research analyst at Pew Research Center, and now works in the U.S. Census Bureau as a survey statistician..

backgrounds are much more likely to lack a sense of self fulfillment in their careers because they face higher pressure to score well.

Financial Pressure

In addition to academic pressure, many students that come from low income families feel forced to pursue higher earning jobs rather than what makes them the most fulfilled. This can be seen in the differences in attitudes of people of color and White people regarding the purpose of their job. A study published by the Pew Research Center analyzed public perception on the value of education, and it was found that White individuals are almost twice as likely as Black or Hispanic individuals “to say their current job is their career”, suggesting that people of color are not fulfilled in their jobs because they don’t want to pursue it as a life-long career (Pew Research Center).⁶ This is further shown by statistics that state Hispanic people “are about twice as likely as whites to say that their current job is just something to get them by”, and the research center acknowledges that that is a disparity reflecting educational differences between Hispanics and Whites (Pew Research Center). This imbalance is also present when comparing the opinions of Black and White individuals. But, how does the actual education system play into this? Michael Hansen – the Chief Executive Officer of Cengage, an education technology company serving millions of learners globally – criticizes the current system claiming that “[it] is not held accountable for ensuring that students are properly equipped with the skills and capabilities to prepare for a career where they can obtain financial stability” (Hansen). He cites that a 2021 Cengage survey found that almost one in five Americans who graduated from some form of higher education did not believe their education provided them with the necessary skills for the

⁶ The Pew Research Center is a nonpartisan organization that produces publications regarding issues, attitudes and trends in the world.

workplace, and that about “half of these college graduates [did] not applied to [entry-level jobs] in their field because they felt unqualified” (Hansen). This leads us to inquire what may be causing this lack of readiness for students.

Social Pressure

Teachers are expected to treat all their students equally, giving them opportunities to push themselves in their knowledge. Sadly, this is not always the case. Due to biases present in the education system, teachers often expect less from students of color compared to White students, which turn into self-fulfilling prophecies in which the student of color will not meet the expectations a teacher holds for a White student. For instance, data from the 2002 Education Longitudinal Study show that “teachers expect 58 percent of white high-school students to obtain a four-year college degree (or more), but anticipate the same for only 37 percent of black students” which foreshadows the result of a significantly higher number of White students graduating college than Black students (Gershenson & Papageorge).⁷ This unequal distribution of expectations does in fact affect a student’s actual performance because when a White teacher is less optimistic of a student who is Black, it negatively affects the teacher’s assessment of that student and the student’s enjoyment in the class (Gershenson & Papageorge). A separate analysis of that same study highlighted that for Black students, “having a non-black teacher in a 10th grade subject made them much less likely to pursue that subject by enrolling in similar classes” which further suggests that prejudiced opinions by teachers have long-term effects on the outcomes of students of color (Rosen).⁸ Because marginalized students are implicitly told that

⁷ Gershenson is an associate professor of public policy and Papageorge is an assistant professor serving separate accredited American universities.

⁸ Rosen is the Director of Media Relations at The John Hopkins University, which is a well recognized institution that is also America’s first research university.

they aren't good enough, they often don't complete their education, and are unable to climb the social ladder. This leads to many of them working dead-end jobs where they don't find any fulfillment.

Conclusion

American students face difficulties in pursuing careers that bring them self fulfillment because of academic, financial, and social influences in the U.S. education system. This is especially true for students who come from disadvantaged backgrounds, such as being low income or a person of color. To ensure that all students are given the opportunities to acquire a meaningful career, the education system must be adjusted to have more equity.

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